

NCOSS-09

Thinking Beyond Just GNU/Linux

The National Conference on Open Source Software, NCOSS-09, was held on May 25 and 26, this year, at the Navi Mumbai campus of C-DAC. It was a step in the right direction in bringing the open source community closer...offering enthusiasts a platform for interaction, workshops and some intellectual stimulation.

From being a niche concept adopted only by the geeks in its earlier years, Open Source Software (OSS) is slowly being welcomed by one and all. Right from desktops to servers, and from data centres to embedded devices, OSS today powers innumerable applications.

NCOSS-09, held on May 25-26, 2009, at the Navi Mumbai campus of C-DAC, brought together the various groups working on developing open source applications catering to specific domains in the ICT world. These included education, health, accessibility, localisation, e-commerce, disaster management, expert systems, machine learning, et al. The gathering was a mix of academia, industry, the open source community and government.

The conference was driven by the OSS division of C-DAC Mumbai. This group is home to the OSSRC (Open Source Software Resource Centre), the first national resource centre in the area of open source, set up jointly by IIT Bombay, IBM and C-DAC Mumbai. Besides the C-DAC initiative, the conference was supported by the IEEE CS chapters of Mumbai and Chennai, along with the Computer Society of India.

And when you have gurus such as Dr

Deepak Phatak of IIT Bombay; Prof C R Muthukrishnan, former deputy director of IIT Chennai, currently advisor to TCS; and Dr S Ramakrishnan, director general of C-DAC; gracing the occasion, the event is a guaranteed winner.

Ensuring the success for such a large and prestigious event requires careful planning and execution. Working in the background was Dr M Sasikumar, associate director, C-DAC (Research). He, along with his team, saw to it that every aspect—right from logistics, lectures and presentations, workshop attendance, food and catering to crowd management, was up to the mark. When quizzed about the elaborate preparations, Dr Sasikumar was upbeat, "This preparation started months in advance when the call for papers was initialised. The NCOSS is intended to act as a forum to promote the adoption of open source software and solutions in different areas, by sharing experiences in solution selection, customisation/adaptation, etc."

He went on to add that a record number of over 110 papers from all over India were submitted to the NCOSS committee. Finally, after a rigorous international refereeing process, about 30 papers were selected and presented during the conference. Further clarifying the role of NCOSS, Dr Sasikumar

The participants at NCOSS

